Lesson 2 · Writing: literary essay preparation, *Macbeth* Acts 1 and 2

Grade 10 English Home Language · Writing and presenting: the literary essay · Ambition, deception and guilt

Grade and subject	Grade 10, English Home Language
Curriculum context	CAPS English Home Language, FET Phase: Writing and presenting (the literary essay) in preparation for the Acts 1 and 2 literature assessment; Literature, p. 26, Shakespeare's *Macbeth*. Annual Teaching Plan Term 3, Week 5.
Duration	45 minutes (one period)
Language skills	Writing (planning PEEL paragraphs); reading and viewing; listening and speaking
Teaching strategies	Guided practice, differentiated instruction, whole-class discussion and debate
Cross-curricular links	History (Jacobean England and fears of witchcraft); Life Orientation (toxic relationship dynamics, deception, ambition, guilt)
Technology	Avoided, to focus on revision, direct engagement and note-taking.
Taught	Abbotts College Pretoria East, 5 August 2026, three Grade 10 classes

Learning outcomes

By the end of the lesson, learners will be able to prepare and study for their upcoming assessment on Acts 1 and 2 of Shakespeare's *Macbeth*, including the ability to critically engage with the themes of ambition, deception and guilt, and to use the PEEL method (Point, Evidence, Explanation, Link) to support their arguments with evidence.

- **Skills:** textual analysis, decoding Shakespearian language, reading dramatic dialogue with appropriate tone, structuring an evidence-based paragraph.
- **Knowledge:** understanding foreshadowing and deception in dramatic contexts.
- **Values and attitudes:** critical awareness of the pressures of ambition, toxic relationship dynamics, deception and guilt.

Theme and key concepts

The corrupting potential of ambition and the consequences of betrayal. A debate on where the agency for Macbeth's treasonous murder of King Duncan lies, linked to the learners' own ambitions and what one would be willing to do to attain one's goals.

- **Hamartia:** a fatal character flaw (from the ancient Greek "to miss the mark").
- **Ambition:** a strong drive towards a personal goal, often involving power or status.

- **Deception:** hiding one's true intentions behind false pretences.
- **Foreshadowing:** hints about future plot points to come.
- **Catalyst:** a moment that drives forward major character change.
- **PEEL method:** Point, Evidence, Explain, Link.

Learning and teaching support materials

- Whiteboard and markers; annotated copies of *Macbeth*
- **LTSM 2 (original):** my one-page revision sheet for Acts 1 and 2, with the 45-minute plan built around ambition, deception and guilt, the PEEL guide and a key-quotation bank keyed to the two essay questions. Download (PDF)

Lesson sequence

Stage	Time	What happens
Hook	10 min	Learners read Act 2 Scene 4 aloud and I explain it section by section, focusing on the unnatural aspects of the day, its darkness and especially the vivid image of the horses eating each other. This leads into a discussion of historical witchcraft and the paranoia around it at the time, and of the supernatural events surrounding the murder of a divinely ordained king as a breakdown of natural order.
Introduction	10 min	The theme of ambition is introduced by asking the class to think of their own personal ambitions and what they would be willing to do to realise them, especially whether they would betray a close friend. What if they felt they could get away with it, and were pressured by a partner? This sets up the discussion of agency and the question of whose fault the king's murder truly is.
Body	20 min	The question of agency runs through the lesson: ambition and three possible places for the blame, the witches (external), Lady Macbeth (interpersonal) and Macbeth himself (internal). The class nominates who they think is at fault, to show the complexity of the issue. We then pivot to deception and guilt, showing how "getting away with it" is complicated by paranoia and spiritual fallout. Learners note key quotations for their PEEL paragraphs as we go.
Consolidation	5 min	To make sure the learners are ready for the assessment, we recap the PEEL method: Point (a strong, debatable claim), Evidence (short quotations embedded naturally in a sentence), Explain (literal meaning, then the connotations of the quotation, tied to the argument) and Link (proving the thesis concretely instead of repeating the Point).

Learner participation

Learners read the scene aloud, share their own ambitions and moral limits, debate and vote on who is to blame for Duncan's murder, give reasons from the text, and take notes of key quotations for the PEEL method. Discussion of the themes and the reasoning behind the blame is learner-led, with close reading of the text as the anchor.

Differentiation

The scene is read aloud and explained section by section, so that learners who struggle with Shakespearian language are not left behind, while the agency debate lets stronger learners argue at a higher level from the same text. The PEEL structure gives every learner a fixed scaffold for the essay, and the revision sheet puts the plan, the quotation bank and the essay questions on one page for learners who need something concrete to

study from. Diagnostic questioning during the lesson shows me who still needs the "divine right of kings" idea explained again before the assessment.

Assessment opportunities

Diagnostic and formative. Direct questioning tests learner readiness for the assessment, checking that they can explain the themes of ambition (with agency) and deception especially. The class vote on blame shows at once who has grasped Macbeth's own agency. The lesson prepares learners for the formal literary essay on Acts 1 and 2, marked with PEEL paragraphs under the school's rules: no standalone quotations, no "I think", and an analysis ladder from literal meaning to word choice to effect to argument.

Reflection after teaching

Focusing on the image of the horses eating each other worked very well; it absolutely caught their attention. The pacing was good. However, I noticed I mentioned some minor things (like recommending a particular adaptation) to some classes and not others, so I will need to pay attention to consistency going forward. They understood the "toxic dynamic" of Lady Macbeth well, but struggled more with the "divine right" of kings. That last point might need to be dealt with again; other than that nothing needs to be re-taught.

Alignment. As per the English HL FET requirements, a text-based and communicative approach was used. Historical context and dramatic imagery were introduced and analysed directly within the play's thematic focuses (ambition, deception and guilt) rather than as isolated historical facts. The PEEL methodology was emphasised, ensuring learners can construct structured, evidence-based literary arguments.

References

- Department of Basic Education. (2011). *Curriculum and Assessment Policy Statement (CAPS): English Home Language Grades 10–12*. Government Printing Works.
- Shakespeare, W. (1992). *The tragedy of Macbeth*. Washington Square Press.